

The Multifaceted Left-Behind Issue*

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1 Introduction

Prima facie, the idea of left-behind admits to a common reference point, a benchmark from which two comparative entities diverge under two possible scenarios. The first conceivable explanation is that events or circumstances led one entity to “pull ahead,” leaving the other behind. Another scenario is that one entity might have been considered to have “fallen behind” because of how slowly it develops. Based on these logical interpretations, Martin *et al.*, (2021b) confirm the latter with their work on “Becoming Left Behind.” Ironically, the current global order, with its far-reaching interconnectedness, has not translated to global equality and convergence (McCann, 2008). On the contrary, spatial inequality is widening - a situation that continues to alarm policymakers, academics, national governments, and other relevant international bodies. Left-behind is multifaceted, having historical, social, geographical, political, economic, cultural and temporal undertones.

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Regarding temporality, there are certain times when the “left-behind” consciousness is triggered, often with political undertones (Pike *et al.*, 2023, p. 9). For instance, the COVID-19 pandemic and the 2008 financial crisis are two unprecedented events yet remarkable periods when the left-behind narrative gained significant amplification (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p. 12). After the 2008 financial crisis, left-behind was prominently featured by Bloomberg, The Economist, and Financial Times magazines ¹. Similarly, at the heart of the 2020 pandemic, left behind was in vogue, used to express vulnerability and discrepancies in vaccine coverage in undeserved places across the globe ². Overtly, the increasing spatial inequalities along national corridors and international boundaries have rekindled interest in “left-behind” regions. Against this backdrop, this article aims to discuss the multifaceted issue of left-behind children.

The remainder is structured as follows: First, we develop a deeper understanding of “left-behind” in light of its historical context; then, we situate it within the political economy discourses, engage the twin discussion of being “left behind” and being “fallen behind”; and finally, unbundle the remedials of left behind by cross examining the contributions made in bridging the spatial inequality gap.

2 “Left-behind”: Historical Context

To begin with, there are different contentions on what “left behind” should be or ought to mean in a bid to be contextually precise and correct. However, for clarity and trans-

¹Bloomberg (2016). The Globalization Debate: Are More Getting Left Behind? <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/videos/2016-08-18/the-globalization-debate-are-more-people-getting-left-behind>
The Economics (2017). The right way to help declining places. <https://www.economist.com/leaders/2017/10/21/the-right-way-to-help-declining-places>
Financial Times (2020). The Economics of Belonging- can globalization work for the left behind?. <https://www.ft.com/content/50efbb96-a4e6-11ea-a27c-b8aa85e36b7e>

²See NBC (2021). ‘Left behind’: For those with weakened immune systems, vaccines have not provided same freedoms. <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/us-news/left-weakened-immune-systems-vaccines-not-provided-freedoms-rcna3595>
World Economic Forum (2022). Leaving no one behind in the wake of COVID-19. <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2022/05/leaving-no-one-behind-in-the-wake-of-covid-19/>

parency, the concept of being “left-behind” is subsumed in geographical inequality caused by long-term processes of uneven development (MacKinnon *et al.*, 2022, p. 41). Although the prominence of “left behind” has recently been attributed to the culmination of discontent, it was initially driven by the recognition and reaction to the ostensibly growing apart regions. Therefore, before discontent, it was first about the spatial imaginary of marginality (MacKinnon *et al.*, 2022, p. 40). From the lenses of the historical development of “left behind”, the earliest record of the phrase could be traced to the codified United States military protocol of “no man left behind” and its subsequent adoption by the Presidential National Advisory on Rural Poverty as a policy response to the spatial concentrations of the rural poor (Pike *et al.*, 2023, p. 3). Additionally, within the international development field, ‘left behind’ is a rhetoric commonly used to explain the development gap between the Global North and South. Of course, not without recourse to the century-long colonial legacy, thus, seeing former empires take on the moral responsibility of indemnifying for the lost decades (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p. 12).

Given the anecdotal scenarios above, the events or circumstances that cause one region to be “left-behind” or “pulled ahead” are multifarious. As argued by Martin *et al.*, (2021b, p 49), it is not a mere historic accident. From the regional science and economic geography perspective, spatial inequality substituted regional convergence in the wake of the globalization crusade (Kemeny and Storper, 2020, p 1). Geographical and economic landscapes were altered as a result of the unprecedented technological advancement and the ensuing economic restructuring (Rodríguez-Pose *et al.*, 2023, p 4). In this new order, the urban core (cities) have now become the beacon of economic fortunes, driving innovation through knowledge concentration and spillovers, generating a self-reinforcing agglomerating force that continues to pull resources – mainly factors of production – to the core (MacKinnon *et al.*, 2022, p 43).

Consequently, this poses a negative externality to the already fragile rural periphery, which is witnessing the outmigration of the younger population, leaving behind an aging

demography (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 22). However, according to Sandhu, globalization is being unduly “scapegoated” in the left-behind discourse footnote 1 (Page 2). On the contrary, labor pooling, concentration of economic activities, and sustained economic growth at the expense of spatial distribution of economic activities are all inextricably linked to globalization (McCann, 2008). And these are the main causes of the sharp geographic divide and the escalating spatial inequality, even in the world’s advanced economies.

3 The Political Economy of "Left-behind"

Remarkably, different worldviews offer significant contributions in theorizing, but more importantly, understanding the left-behind discourse in the light of spatial inequality. For instance, human capital, innovation, and knowledge are critical pivots of the endogenous growth theory (Barca *et al.*, 2012, p 3). Unlike the forced migration of labor that characterized the colonial era, under the current neo-liberal regime, skilled labor now voluntarily migrates to specific locations, where opportunities continue to cluster (Rodríguez-Pose *et al.*, 2023; Wise, 2015). Unsurprisingly, the decade-long integration of advanced knowledge and disruptive innovation has put some regions ahead of others, thus creating a leading-lagging situation where skilled labor from the relatively disadvantaged regions is trooping in to meet the labor demand (Kemeny and Storper, 2020). Although with globalization, the potential exists for technological innovations to diffuse across regions, the flow is uneven and most significantly constrained by the disparity in development (Kemeny, Petralia, *et al.*, 2022, p 1).

The multiplicity of this is what constitutes the political economy of the left-behind. In particular, the overlapping antecedents of economy and politics cannot be downplayed in the geography of inequality. As summed up by Martin *et al.*, (2021a, p 12), it is a locked-in effect of certain benefits in some places while simultaneously locking others out of prosperity. Simply put, it is a paradox of temperate (cold) regions having more abundant solar

energy infrastructure than tropical (hot) regions with more than average daylight exposure. Historically, plausible explanations for why some regions “pulled ahead” rapidly, leaving others behind include *inter alia* the post war back down on Keynesian and welfare policy consensus and more importantly, taking the austerity back door in charting a new course for economic resurgence (Pike *et al.*, 2023; Martin *et al.*, 2021b). While this has since defined spatial imbalance between Global North and South, at the sub-national level, particularly in North America and Europe, regional inequality is a significant national quagmire that is drawing enormous attention (MacKinnon *et al.*, 2022, p 25). This is true of the “rustbelt” in the United States, the inner areas (“*Aree Interne*”) in Italy, peripheral France (“*La France périphérique*”), the suspended regions (“*abgehängte Regionen*”) in Germany, the shrinking areas (“*Krimpgebieden*”) in the Netherlands, and the hollowed-out Spain (“*la España vaciada*”) (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 12).

The economic decisions made by these countries while transitioning from the previous industrial revolution restructured their economic landscape into an urban core and a rural periphery, ending up creating “winners” and “losers” (Rodríguez-Pose *et al.*, 2023). With shifting economic geography, rural, smaller townships, and former industrial estates (which were hit by the deinstitutionalization wave) begin to lag in the new paradigm of global competitiveness (Pike *et al.*, 2023, p 4). Furthermore, in the face of a shrinking demography, socio-economic and political disconnect and other infrastructural deficits, the effects of metropolitanization or rather peripheralization, on these regions become further entrenched (Pike *et al.*, 2023; Leibert and Golinski, 2016). By connecting the dots, it becomes clear that this perceived marginalization is what sparked discontent in these “left-behind” places. Increasingly, this situation is gaining traction for different reasons and in other instances, it is being exploited for both political and economic interests. Particularly, the complex dynamics of “left-behind” have been linked to the rise of populism and economic nationalism in these regions (Rodríguez-Pose *et al.*, 2023, p 3). This has been used by politicians to sway elections by feigning deference to the concerns of com-

munities that are being “left-behind” while simultaneously promoting their agenda as the only solution to their impasse. For the electorates in those ostracized regions, the election is another medium to stamp their discontent (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 15).

Admittedly, the scope of “left-behind” discourse is broad, extending beyond the economic and political correlates of spatial inequality. Thus, considering the socio-cultural and environmental dimensions of the discourse will further broaden and enrich the understanding of “left-behind” issues. Noticeably, there are debates on the changing dynamic of the socio-cultural habitus of these places, much so the concern around people’s ‘sense of place’ (Withers, 2009). So far, one has been addressed, which reckons with how the new economic regime continues to lure people—especially the younger generation—out of the economically “disadvantaged” zones (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 22). For individuals who later move, it is a tradeoff between place attachment and economic incentives. On the other end of the spectrum, people who are culturally attached to their environment often decide to stay – the older population, though not exclusively, fall into this category (Pike *et al.*, 2023, p 4). For them, it is a decision to “stay behind” rather than being “left-behind”, demonstrating the affective bond people have with the environment they inhabit (MacKinnon *et al.*, 2022, p 45). Sadly, the sustainability of these places is under threat, so long as spatial inequality continues unabated. More like a case of historic communities being deserted and abandoned, and over time, continuous abandonment could erode completely the socio-cultural capital and sense of community remaining in those places (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 19).

4 The Twin Debate

Having considered the circumstances under which certain regions “pulled ahead” while leaving others behind, it is pertinent to emphasize the second anecdotal scenario. The “left-behind” discourse rarely, if ever, focuses on the actions or inaction that lead to “be-

coming left behind,” as Martin *et al.*, (2021b) put it. If so, would this vitally contribute to the “left-behind” discourse? Perhaps. At the supranational level, specifically, when benchmarking against development in former colonies, institutional economics maintains that vibrant institutional capacity is sacrosanct to development and a fall off, that is, weak institutions can cause regions to remain behind (Barca *et al.*, 2012). As such, among other things, the drawback to “catching up” or development in such regions could be attributed to their institutional capacity – a distinctive argument on the North-South divide. Although it has some merit, this position does not resonate with the worldview of decolonial thought, which argues that the institutional capacity in these regions is a function of colonial legacy. This line of reasoning contends that the lasting legacy of colonization on the former colony cannot be detached from its many years of undermining state building (Ali *et al.*, 2018), institutional formation (De Juan and Pierskalla, 2017; Tusalem, 2016), distorting socio-cultural reproduction and impairing native linguistic development (Sayedayn, 2021; Mufwene, n.d.).

Fundamentally, these have been found to be crucial for knowledge and innovation capacity and, most importantly, economic development (Mateus Martins, 2017). However, the emergence of the Asian Tigers and a few other nations transitioning up the development ranks in recent years file an exception to this rule. But again, it is important to tread with caution because the impact varies in magnitude and more so, the context may differ, particularly the kind of rule (whether direct or indirect) could make the distinction (De Juan and Pierskalla, 2017). In the end, it is impossible to completely absolve former colonial empires—which essentially comprises nations that have “pulled ahead”—of the reason why the majority of former colonies are “left-behind”. But regardless of whether the left-behind issue is the result of the changing economic paradigm or years of disruptions, it is a major concern on all fronts.

Along with being a long-standing issue, it has a history of numerous interventions meant to close the gap. Often articulated along geographical, institutional, socio-, political-

economic dimensions or even policy corollaries, these interventions are embedded in contextual or ideological purveyors like “catching-up,” “closing the gap,” “convergence,” “levelling up,” “spatial rebalancing,” among others. As far back as the 1960s in the United States, the Presidential National Advisory Commission on Rural Poverty was already alerted to the risk of poverty in its rural areas while figuring out potential policy responses (Pike *et al.*, 2023, p 2-3). More than half a century later, the European Union is still tackling spatial inequality and left-behind issues, particularly with its very recent policy intervention on social and economic cohesion throughout its territory (Commission, 2022). Similarly, for the United Kingdom, reviving productivity growth – prioritizing the equalization of welfare and opportunities is central to addressing the left-behind predicaments.

In all of these, the overarching goal is to achieve regional convergence, that is, ensuring the vertical spread of opportunities and economic gains. In contrast, both have been found to be mutually exclusive—it is either sustained national growth or social equality (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 24), raising concerns about maintaining global competitiveness at the same time achieving social equality. Next, is inquiring whether the pandering to left-behind issues at both the subnational and supranational level is consistent with genuine intentions to bridge the spatial inequality gap. The answer to this will undoubtedly serve as the benchmark for evaluating the effectiveness of these interventions and the concerns around rising spatial inequalities. For example, at the supranational level, several years of sinking aid and other forms of financial assistance in left-behind regions has not translated to levelling up in development or reducing inequality. Conversely, the effectiveness of this has however come under intense scrutiny within the field of development (Moyo, 2009, p 40). Or is it the debate that this supports create dependency rather than foster development? (Evans, 2016). More specifically, the effectiveness of aid in left behind regions are being subject to questioning regarding issues around bureaucracies, misplaced priorities, place- and need-based interventions, compounded by the political will on the

recipients' side (Moyo, 2009; Easterly, 2007). At the subnational level also, the barrage of projects, initiatives and infrastructural development is unconvincing in the levelling up commitment (Martin *et al.*, 2021a, p 24).

5 Conclusion

In conclusion, we have discussed the multifaceted “left-behind” issue from two different perspectives: the circumstances that accelerated the development of some regions and the likely circumstances that might have kept the other regions behind. Overall, the “left-behind” issue is not recent; it has a long history of processes that have caused regions to drift apart. Apparently with globalization, it is increasingly difficult for regions to converge despite extensive global interconnectedness. Really, the modern economic landscape of sustained economic growth is powered by agglomeration, and the ripple effects have an unprecedented impact on geographical reorganization. This ends up creating “winners” and “losers” along national corridors and international boundaries, leaving two options: fall in or fight it. The latter could be seen in light of the recent rise in populism and economic nationalism. So far, efforts made to close the gap between “left-behind” and “pulled ahead” regions could not have been said to be effective. Often, it is the case of using the wrong pill for a diagnosis. If the intentions are genuine on addressing the issues of left-behind and elevating welfare opportunities, standard of living, and economic prosperity, critical interventions should be in technological and innovative exchange, human capital development in “left-behind” regions.

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